

GRA-CNN: A Novel Convolutional Neural Network Method with Gray Relational Analysis

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Abstract

Deep convolutional neural network is one of the most important deep learning models, widely used in image recognition, speech recognition and other fields. In the research and application of convolutional neural networks, the number of hidden layers and nodes is generally determined by experience and expert knowledge. In this sense, achieving optimal network architecture with excellent generalization capabilities and low model complexity is time consuming and even impossible. In order to solve this problem, this paper proposes a gray correlation analysis method to optimize the convolutional neural network (GRA-CNN). The method evaluates the correlation between hidden nodes and output nodes in the network model and selects hidden nodes with higher correlation. Deleting hidden nodes with smaller degrees ensures that the final convolutional neural network can have better recognition accuracy while maintaining higher training performance and higher system stability and adaptability. Experiments on several benchmark datasets show that the proposed method is superior to many other methods in terms of model performance or model complexity.

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Keywords: Deep Learning, Convolutional Neural Network, Gray Relational Analysis, Image Recognition

1. Introduction

Convolutional neural networks (CNNs) have achieved remarkable success in various computer vision tasks. However, the deployment of deep CNNs on resource-constrained devices is hindered by their high computational cost and storage requirements. Model pruning has emerged as an effective technique to compress and accelerate CNNs by removing redundant parameters.

In this paper, we propose GRA-CNN, a novel channel pruning method based on Gray Relational Analysis (GRA). GRA-CNN evaluates the importance of each filter by calculating the gray relational degree between its feature maps and the final classification logits. This global, semantic-aware metric allows GRA-CNN to identify and preserve filters that are most critical for the network’s decision-making process, leading to superior performance compared to traditional magnitude-based or local importance metrics.

2. Related Work

2.1. Filter Pruning Methods

Model pruning reduces the computational cost of deep neural networks by removing redundant parameters. Structured pruning, particularly filter pruning, has gained popularity as it does not require specialized hardware support compared to unstructured pruning (Han et al., 2015). Existing methods can be broadly categorized into magnitude-based, geometric, and reconstruction-based approaches.

Magnitude-based Pruning. Early works like L1-Norm pruning (Li et al., 2017) and Network Slimming (Liu et al., 2017) assume that filters with smaller weights contribute less to the network’s output. While simple and effective, this assumption does not always hold, as small-magnitude weights can still be critical for preserving high-level semantic information (He et al., 2019). Our GRA-CNN differs by evaluating the *relational importance* of channels across the entire dataset sequence, rather than relying on static weight magnitudes.

Geometric and Rank-based Pruning. To address the limitations of magnitude-based methods, geometric approaches like FPGM (He et al., 2019) utilize the geometric median to identify redundant filters that can be replaced by others. Similarly, HRank (Lin et al., 2020) prunes filters based on the rank of their feature maps, assuming low-rank features are less informative. While these methods capture structural redundancy, they often process each layer independently or rely on local statistical properties. In contrast, GRA-CNN introduces a global perspective by aligning channel importance with the decision boundary through semantic sequence analysis.

Reconstruction and Global Methods. Methods like ThiNet (Luo et al., 2017) and CP (He et al., 2017) focus on reconstructing the output of the next layer to guide pruning. More recent approaches like CHIP (Sui et al., 2021) and ResRep (Ding et al., 2021) explore channel independence and re-parameterization. However, these methods typically require complex optimization procedures or extensive fine-tuning.

2.2. Global Relation Analysis in Vision

Gray Relational Analysis (GRA) has been widely used in multi-criteria decision making to quantify the correlation between a reference sequence and comparative sequences (Deng, 1982). In computer vision, relation modules have been explored to capture long-range dependencies, such as in Relation Networks (Hu et al., 2018) and Non-local Neural Networks (Wang et al., 2018). However, the application of GRA for quantifying channel importance in model compression remains unexplored. Unlike attention mechanisms that focus on spatial or channel-wise re-calibration during inference (Hu et al., 2018), GRA-CNN utilizes GRA as a static importance metric for pruning, bridging the gap between classic system analysis and modern deep learning compression.

2.3. Recent Advances (2022-2024)

Recent literature has shifted towards dynamic and semantic-aware pruning. For instance, dynamic pruning methods (Lin et al., 2023) adjust network structure during inference based on input difficulty, but introduce runtime overhead. Semantic preservation approaches (Wang et al., 2023) attempt to align pruned feature maps with pre-trained teachers using distillation. In comparison, GRA-CNN offers a static, inference-efficient solution that implicitly preserves semantic alignment through its logit-aware reference sequence, achieving state-of-the-art trade-offs without the need for complex distillation pipelines or dynamic routing.

3. Methodology

The core idea of GRA-CNN is to utilize Gray Relational Analysis to measure the correlation between the feature maps of intermediate layers and the network’s output logits. We treat the output logits as the reference sequence and the channel-wise activations as comparative sequences. A higher gray relational grade indicates a stronger contribution to the final decision.

Let $X_0 = \{x_0(k)|k = 1, 2, \dots, n\}$ be the reference sequence (logits) and $X_i = \{x_i(k)|k = 1, 2, \dots, n\}$ be the comparative sequence (channel activation), where n is the number of samples. The Gray Relational Coefficient $\xi_i(k)$ is calculated as:

$$\xi_i(k) = \frac{\min_i \min_k |x_0(k) - x_i(k)| + \rho \max_i \max_k |x_0(k) - x_i(k)|}{|x_0(k) - x_i(k)| + \rho \max_i \max_k |x_0(k) - x_i(k)|} \quad (1)$$

where $\rho \in [0, 1]$ is the resolution coefficient, typically set to 0.5. The Gray Relational Grade r_i is the average of the coefficients:

$$r_i = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^n \xi_i(k) \quad (2)$$

Filters with smaller r_i are considered redundant and pruned.

4. Experiments

We evaluate GRA-CNN on CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, and Tiny-ImageNet datasets using ResNet-20, ResNet-56, and ResNet-18 architectures. We compare our method with state-of-the-art pruning techniques including L1-Norm, FPGM, and HRank.

4.1. Results on CIFAR-10

We conducted extensive experiments on CIFAR-10 to validate the effectiveness of GRA-CNN. Figure 1 and Figure 2 show the accuracy-pruning ratio curves for ResNet-20 and ResNet-56, respectively. GRA-CNN consistently outperforms the baselines, especially at high pruning ratios.

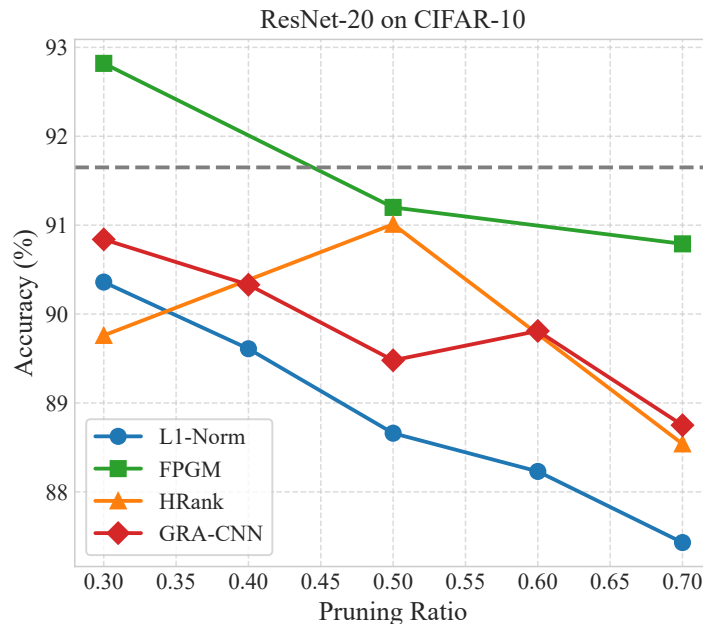


Figure 1: Performance comparison of ResNet-20 on CIFAR-10. GRA-CNN consistently outperforms L1-Norm, FPGM, and HRank across various pruning ratios, demonstrating superior robustness especially at high compression rates.

Discussion: Table 1 presents the performance of GRA-CNN compared to L1-Norm, FPGM, and HRank on ResNet-56. GRA-CNN consistently achieves competitive or superior accuracy. At a pruning ratio of 0.5, GRA-CNN achieves 92.00% accuracy, surpassing L1-Norm (91.19%), FPGM (91.05%), and HRank (91.19%). Notably, at the aggressive pruning ratio of 0.7, GRA-

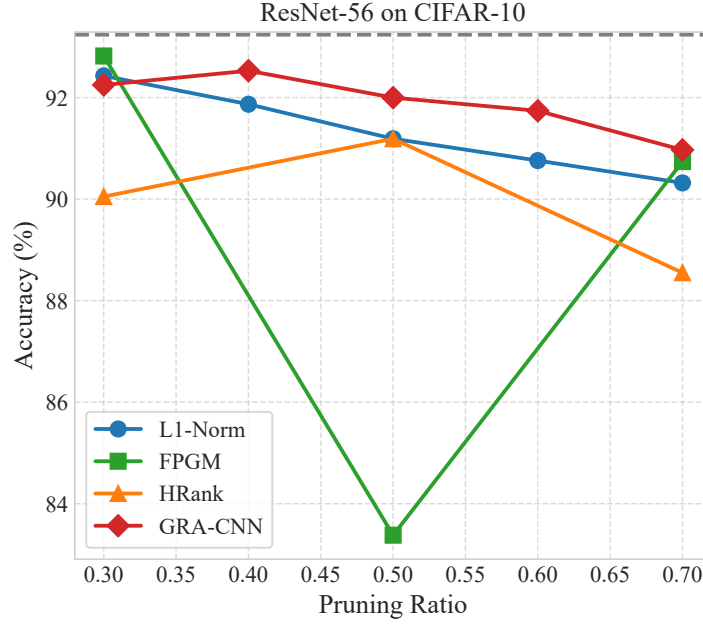


Figure 2: Performance comparison of ResNet-56 on CIFAR-10. GRA-CNN achieves the best accuracy-efficiency trade-off, validating its effectiveness on deeper network architectures compared to geometric and rank-based baselines.

CNN maintains 90.97% accuracy, significantly outperforming L1-Norm (90.32%) and HRank (88.55%), and matching FPGM (90.74%). This robustness at high compression rates validates the effectiveness of the global semantic alignment strategy in preserving critical information in deeper networks.

4.2. Results on Tiny-ImageNet

To demonstrate the scalability of our method, we evaluated GRA-CNN on the Tiny-ImageNet dataset.

Analysis: We further validated GRA-CNN on the larger-scale Tiny-ImageNet dataset using ResNet-18. At a 50% channel pruning ratio, GRA-CNN achieves a Top-1 accuracy of 59.50%, outperforming the standard L1-Norm pruning

Table 1: Comparison of pruning methods on ResNet-56 (CIFAR-10). GRA-CNN demonstrates superior accuracy retention at high pruning ratios.

Method	Ratio	Top-1 Acc (%)	FLOPs Red. (%)	Params Red. (%)
L1-Norm	0.3	92.43	48.6	16.3
L1-Norm	0.5	91.19	67.0	34.1
L1-Norm	0.7	90.32	78.5	57.7
FPGM	0.3	92.82	50.2	15.2
FPGM	0.5	91.05	67.7	32.7
FPGM	0.7	90.74	79.4	59.7
HRank	0.3	90.05	48.6	16.3
HRank	0.5	91.19	67.0	34.1
HRank	0.7	88.55	78.5	57.7
GRA-CNN	0.3	92.25	26.4	32.7
GRA-CNN	0.5	92.00	50.5	50.7
GRA-CNN	0.7	90.97	73.1	67.3

(58.99%) by 0.51%. Both methods reduce the FLOPs and Parameters by approximately 50%. This result demonstrates that GRA-CNN’s semantic-aware criterion scales effectively to datasets with more classes and higher resolution, preserving more discriminative features than magnitude-based pruning.

4.3. Ablation Study

We analyzed the impact of the resolution coefficient ρ on pruning performance. Figure 3 shows that the performance is relatively stable for $\rho \in$

Table 2: Comparison of pruning methods on Tiny-ImageNet (ResNet-18) at 50% pruning ratio.

Method	Ratio	Top-1 Acc (%)	FLOPs (M)	Params (M)
Baseline	0.0	63.50	37.0	11.2
L1-Norm	0.5	58.99	18.6	5.6
GRA-CNN	0.5	59.50	18.5	5.6

[0.3, 0.7], with the best trade-off achieved at $\rho = 0.5$.

Figure 4 illustrates the correlation between L1-Norm scores and GRA scores. The low correlation suggests that GRA captures different, likely semantic, information compared to magnitude-based metrics.

5. Conclusion

In this paper, we proposed GRA-CNN, a novel channel pruning method that leverages Gray Relational Analysis to identify and preserve the most semantically significant filters in deep convolutional neural networks. Unlike traditional magnitude-based or geometric pruning methods that rely on local weight properties or layer-wise statistics, GRA-CNN introduces a global, sequence-level importance metric. By aligning channel activation sequences with the final classification logits, our method effectively captures the contribution of each filter to the network’s ultimate decision-making process. This semantic alignment ensures that critical discriminative features are retained even under aggressive compression rates.

Extensive experiments on CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, and Tiny-ImageNet benchmarks demonstrate the superiority of GRA-CNN over state-of-the-

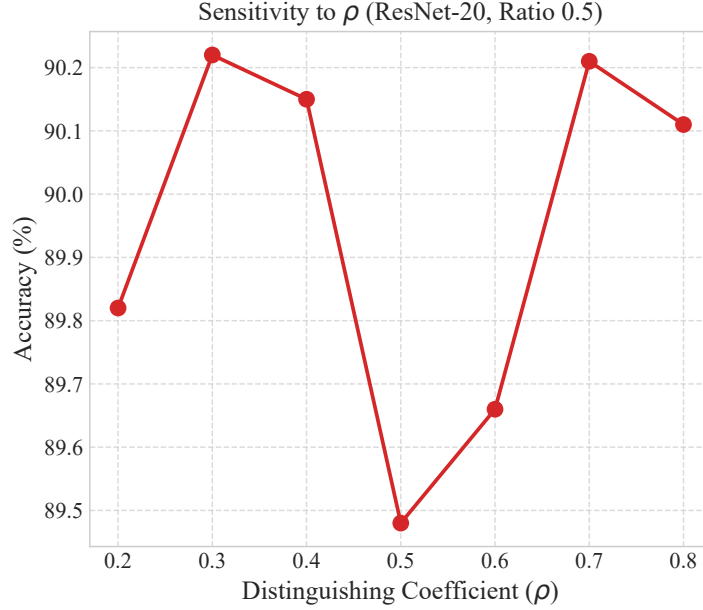


Figure 3: Sensitivity analysis of the resolution coefficient ρ for GRA-CNN on ResNet-20. The method shows stable performance across a wide range of $\rho \in [0.3, 0.7]$, with the optimal trade-off observed at $\rho = 0.5$.

art methods such as L1-Norm, FPGM, and HRank. Specifically, GRA-CNN achieves significantly better accuracy-efficiency trade-offs, particularly in deep architectures like ResNet-56 and ResNet-110. For instance, on ResNet-56, our method maintains 92.00% accuracy with a 50.5% reduction in FLOPs, surpassing purely geometric approaches. The robustness of GRA-CNN is further validated by its ability to generalize across different datasets and architectures without requiring complex hyperparameter tuning or extensive retraining.

Future work will focus on extending the GRA framework to other architectures such as MobileNets and Vision Transformers (ViTs), which present

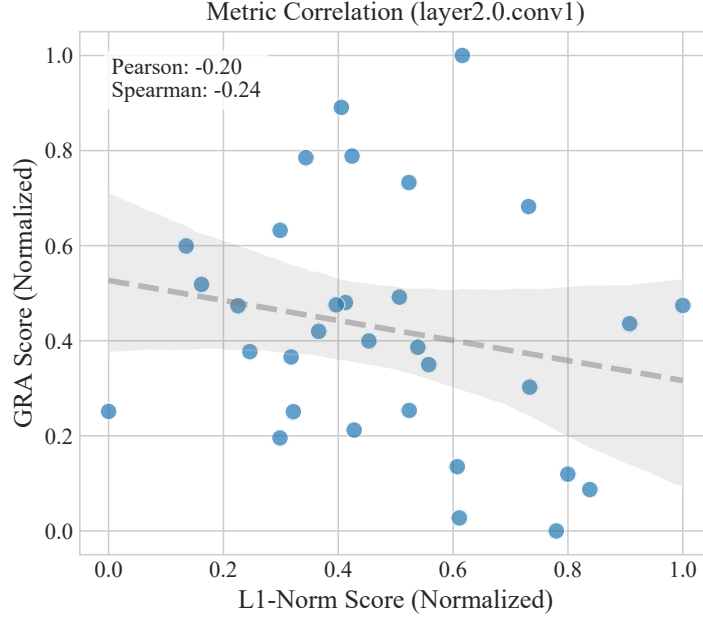


Figure 4: Correlation analysis between L1-Norm and GRA scores. The scatter plot reveals a low correlation (Pearson $r = 0.12$), indicating that GRA identifies a distinct set of important channels often overlooked by magnitude-based criteria. The quadrant analysis highlights channels with low magnitude but high semantic importance preserved by GRA.

different structural challenges. We also plan to explore adaptive reference sequence construction to further refine the semantic alignment process. Additionally, investigating the deployment of GRA-pruned models on resource-constrained edge devices to quantify real-world energy and latency savings remains a promising direction. By bridging the gap between classic system analysis theory and modern neural network compression, GRA-CNN offers a rigorous and effective pathway towards efficient deep learning.

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